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Culture (OWC): [San \(FX10\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1966-1974

Coverage Date: 1966-1974

Place Coverage

Kade area, Central Kalahari Game Reserve, Botswana

Section Title(S): Labor

As one criterion for the amount of labor performed by the providers, we can measure the time they spend out hunting and gathering. Table 16 shows the time spent getting food by the sixteen providers of the !Koi!kom camp for the ten-day period from October 4 to 13, 1967. The reason that the total for the men on October 12 is so great is that all the men except N/araji and Ayakxoi went off in pursuit of a gemsbok that /Ug#ama had shot the day before. The women, almost certain of having meat that night, spent little time out gathering. The next day, October 13, as there was still some meat left over, hardly anyone left camp. At this time the main food was the root *Cucumis kalahariensis*, and the reason that the women spent so little time in the field on October 8 was that they had put in long hours the day before and still had plenty of food left.

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The table clearly shows that the men are out much longer than the women, and also that there is great variation from person to person. For example, Kenen/u and his wife Shie!kaho were still young and childless and had no family to support, so neither of them had to spend much time procuring food; and Ayakxoi had hurt his foot and could not go hunting, so his time out was far less than the others. The total time in the field for the sixteen providers in the ten-day period was 743 hours and 35 minutes (there were fourteen dependents). The daily average per person was: 743 hrs 35 mins $\times$ 1/10 (days) $\times$ 1/16 (persons) = 4 hrs 39 mins.

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Of course, besides individual variation, the time spent depends also on the type of plant gathered and the method of hunting used, and varies from season to season as well. Including data from other camps at other times of

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the year, however, we can conclude that the women go out from one to five hours almost every day, while the men go out three to five days a week for five to twelve hours. The average figures correspond more or less with those in Table 16. Since the sun's rays beat down mercilessly on the Kalahari most of the year the San often stop to rest in the shade during their day's work; thus the actual time spent working in the field is somewhat less than the figures shown in the table.

But the San's work is not limited to hunting and gathering: there are also various tasks to be done in camp. The camp chore requiring the most time is food preparation, a job which falls to the women, who spend less time out of camp. The men, on days when they do not go out hunting, make and repair leather goods and hunting tools. Such work, however, probably takes not more than two hours a day. Among the  78 incessant chatting that takes place whenever a number of people are gathered in camp, some subjects have a direct relationship to the San's daily life, such as the availability and distribution of plants and animals, decisions pertaining to moving camp, censure and judging of those who have violated social strictures, or a marriage in the family. Because such conversations help San society to function smoothly, we might consider them as labor. Most of San conversation, however, consists rather of rumors, slandering, jokes, and other such light and amusing matter, so I will simplify things by restricting the term "labor" to physical labor only.

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